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Only a few years ago, when laptops were a novelty, they were considered expensive toys. Anyone carrying a laptop was assumed to be either a rich geek or a corporate biggie flaunting his status or making a style statement.

Today, of course, the case is vastly different. And while laptops have become common, another genre has spawned: the lifestyle laptop. These combine top-of-the-line hardware with the most gorgeous-looking exteriors you could hope for. These are geared specially for those who enjoy showing off, like gamers and businessmen!

The deadly combination of looks and performance make these laptops objects of desire. They are something to be owned, and are not meant for those who just want a laptop for work.

Well, what constitutes a lifestyle laptop? This is hugely influenced by the brand of the laptop and also on its looks, design and build quality. And a designer name thrown in is the icing on the cake!

Nineteen laptops arrived for our comparison test. The Apple PowerBook G4 was one of them, but we didn't compare it head-on with the other laptops because the platform is different.

Fujitsu sent in four laptops, one of which was a tablet PC—which, again, had to be excluded from the comparison and reviewed separately. It would not have been fair to pit a tablet PC against regular laptops.

Samsung, too, sent in four laptops, of which one had a 17-inch monitor, which was way bigger than the rest, and so even its form factor was the largest. It, too, was reviewed separately.

The remaining sixteen laptops were divided into two categories based on form factor, and were unleashed against each other. It was a fight to the finish, with the best-looking and the most powerful facing off.

LIFESTYLE ULTRA-PORTABLES

Ultra-portable laptops are designed to minimise size and weight, while at the same time trying to keep the features and computing power of their larger siblings. These laptops are easier to carry around and are largely aimed towards frequent travellers. It is these laptops that make a style statement.

We categorised the laptops as ultra-portables and workhorses based on their screen size and weight. The ultra-portable category comprised laptops that had a diagonal screen size below 14 inches and weighed less than two kg—in other words, small form factor laptops.

Of the 19 laptops we received, eight of them, from six manufacturers, made it to this category. These included the Acer TravelMate, Dell Latitude X1, Fujitsu LifeBook LBP7010 and LBS6240, MSI MegaBook S260 and S270, Samsung Note PC Q30, and the Sony VAIO VGN-S46GP/S.

Features

The Processor

Most laptops in this category were based on Intel Centrino technology, which means they sported

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Intel Pentium M processors, included Intel 855 boards, and had Intel 802.11b+g Wi-Fi, all of which are certified as low-energy consuming parts by Intel—hence the Centrino certification.

One exception was the MSI MegaBook S270, which had an AMD Sempron 3000+, and was based on the ATI Radeon Xpress 200P chipset.

The RAM

While most of the laptops had 512 MB, the MSIs had just 256 MB. The Acer TravelMate, Dell Latitude X1, Fujitsu LBS6240 and the Sony VAIO all came equipped with DDR2 memory, while the rest came with DDR memory; this made a difference in the memory bandwidth benchmarks and in applications affected by RAM.

The Display

Almost all these laptops featured a 12.1-inch display. The Sony VAIO and the Fujitsu LBS6240 each featured a 13.3-inch screen, and the Fujitsu LBP7010 featured the tiniest of displays at 10.6 inches. The widescreen aspect ratio was common, with the exception of Fujitsu LBS6240 whose display had a regular 4:3 aspect ratio.

In native display resolutions too, the LBS6240 lagged behind at 1024 x 768, where the others supported either 1280 x 768 or 1280 x 800. It is worth noting that the Sony VAIO had the best display with very wide viewing angles.

Ports And Connectivity

Four of the laptops here had three USB ports each, while the remaining four had two each. Every laptop had a FireWire port for high-speed video capture from supported devices. The serial and parallel ports are now obsolete. The Acer laptop and Fujitsu's LBS6240 had the port replicator option to add more ports.

Infrared connectivity was available only in two of the eight laptops—the Acer TravelMate 3002WTCi and Fujitsu LBS6240—whereas Bluetooth was available on the Acer TravelMate, Dell Latitude X1, MSI MegaBook S260 and S270 and the Sony VAIO.

All the laptops were WiFi-conformant with

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Sony VAIO VGN-S46/GP

Imaging: Shivali S Photograph: Sandeep Patil